# God Be Merciful to Me a Sinner

*God turns away the proud who trust in their own goodness, and he receives the humble who come asking for mercy.*

| Main passage | Luke 18:9-14 (KJV) |
|---|---|
| **Topic** | Pride |
| **Audience** | adults |
| **Length** | about 45 minutes |
| **Status** | Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave |

## Suggested timing

| Opening | 4 min |
|---|---|
| **Scripture** | 3 min |
| **Background** | 5 min |
| **Teaching point 1: Pride trusts itself and looks down on others** | 7 min |
| **Teaching point 2: Humility comes empty-handed** | 7 min |
| **Teaching point 3: God exalts the humble** | 7 min |
| **Discussion questions** | 7 min |
| **Application** | 3 min |
| **Closing prayer** | 2 min |
| **Total** | 45 min |

## Opening (4 min)

Ask: "If you had to pick the most religious person in your town, who would it be, and why?" (Do not ask for names; ask what makes a person look religious.) Then explain that in Jesus' day the answer would have been a Pharisee, and the least religious would have been a tax collector. Jesus tells a story with both, and the ending surprised everyone.

## Scripture (3 min)

**Luke 18:9-14**

9 And he spake this parable unto certain which trusted in themselves that they were righteous, and despised others: 10 Two men went up into the temple to pray; the one a Pharisee, and the other a publican. 11 The Pharisee stood and prayed thus with himself, God, I thank thee, that I am not as other men are, extortioners, unjust, adulterers, or even as this publican. 12 I fast twice in the week, I give tithes of all that I possess. 13 And the publican, standing afar off, would not lift up so much as his eyes unto heaven, but smote

upon his breast, saying, God be merciful to me a sinner. [14] I tell you, this man went down to his house justified rather than the other: for every one that exalteth himself shall be abased; and he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

Read the passage aloud. Have one reader read the Pharisee's prayer in a proud voice and another read the publican's prayer quietly.

## Background (5 min)

Luke tells us exactly why Jesus told this parable: "unto certain which trusted in themselves that they were righteous, and despised others" (v. 9). Pharisees were respected religious leaders, devoted to the law. Publicans collected taxes for the Roman occupiers, often dishonestly, and were seen as traitors.

The Pharisee's claims were true. He fasted twice a week, more than the law required, and tithed everything. His problem was not his deeds but whom he trusted and how he looked at others.

## Teaching point 1: Pride trusts itself and looks down on others (7 min)

The Pharisee "prayed thus with himself." His prayer was really a speech about himself, with a sideways glance at the sinner nearby. Pride uses others as a measuring stick, and always finds someone worse to stand above.

### Supporting verses

**Luke 18:9-12:** And he spake this parable unto certain which trusted in themselves that they were righteous, and despised others: Two men went up into the temple to pray; the one a Pharisee, and the other a publican. The Pharisee stood and prayed thus with himself, God, I thank thee, that I am not as other men are, extortioners, unjust, adulterers, or even as this publican. I fast twice in the week, I give tithes of all that I possess.

**Proverbs 16:18:** Pride goeth before destruction, and an haughty spirit before a fall.

**Romans 12:3:** For I say, through the grace given unto me, to every man that is among you, not to think of himself more highly than he ought to think; but to think soberly, according as God hath dealt to every man the measure of faith.

> *"They did not trust to God or the Messiah for righteousness, but to their own works."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 18:9

> *"Our Lord grants that the Pharisees made clean the outside: but, alas! what pride, vain glory, and contempt for others, were lodged within!"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 18:9

### Handout blanks (answers)

They trusted in themselves that they were **righteous**.

Pride measures itself against **other** people.

## Teaching point 2: Humility comes empty-handed  (7 min)

The publican stood far off, would not look up, beat his breast, and prayed seven words: "God be merciful to me a sinner." He offered no record, no excuses and no comparisons, only his need and God's mercy. Strangely, standing far off was the way to come near to God.

### Supporting verses

**Luke 18:13:** And the publican, standing afar off, would not lift up so much as his eyes unto heaven, but smote upon his breast, saying, God be merciful to me a sinner.

**Psalm 51:17:** The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit: a broken and a contrite heart, O God, thou wilt not despise.

**Isaiah 57:15:** For thus saith the high and lofty One that inhabiteth eternity, whose name is Holy; I dwell in the high and holy place, with him also that is of a contrite and humble spirit, to revive the spirit of the humble, and to revive the heart of the contrite ones.

> *"as unworthy to draw near; but that was the way to get near"*
> — David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 18:13

> *"because he was a true penitent, and felt himself utterly unworthy to appear before God."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 18:13

### Handout blanks (answers)

God be **merciful** to me a sinner.

The publican came to God with nothing but his **need**.

## Teaching point 3: God exalts the humble  (7 min)

"This man went down to his house justified rather than the other" (v. 14). The religious man went home unchanged; the sinner went home right with God. Jesus states the rule of his kingdom: everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, and whoever humbles himself will be exalted.

### Supporting verses

**Luke 18:14:** I tell you, this man went down to his house justified rather than the other: for every one that exalteth himself shall be abased; and he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

**James 4:6:** But he giveth more grace. Wherefore he saith, God resisteth the proud, but giveth grace unto the humble.

**1 Peter 5:5:** Likewise, ye younger, submit yourselves unto the elder. Yea, all of you be subject one to another, and be clothed with humility: for God resisteth the proud, and giveth grace to the humble.

> *"for the Pharisee was not seeking justification, and felt no need of it."*
> — David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 18:14

### Handout blanks (answers)

This man went down to his house **justified** rather than the other.

He that humbleth himself shall be **exalted**.

## Discussion questions (7 min)

**1. What was good about the Pharisee's life? What was wrong with his prayer?**

His disciplines were real; but he trusted them, thanked God mainly for himself, and despised others.

**2. In what subtle ways do we compare ourselves with others to feel better?**

Thinking "at least I'm not like …", judging other churches, families, or generations.

**3. Why is "God be merciful to me a sinner" such a powerful prayer?**

It is honest, humble, and rests entirely on God's mercy; it is the doorway to forgiveness.

**4. How can we hold high standards without falling into the Pharisee's pride?**

Remembering that every good thing in us is by grace, measuring ourselves by Christ rather than by others, and staying aware of our own need.

## Application (3 min)

Each day this week, pray the publican's prayer slowly and sincerely. When you catch yourself thinking "at least I'm not like them," stop and pray for that person instead.

## Closing prayer (2 min)

God, be merciful to me a sinner. We confess that we have trusted in ourselves and looked down on others. Take away our pride, and give us humble hearts that rely only on your mercy. Thank you that you lift up the humble and receive all who come to you through Jesus Christ. Amen.

## Sources quoted

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 18:9

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 18:9

David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 18:13

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 18:13

David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 18:14

*Every quotation was checked word for word against the library text it cites. All sources are in the public domain.*